do not see the other side's military moves as defensive. Their interpretations of past agreements, of the significance of their policies and responses to each other at critical moments, and the chronology of events are gulfs apart. If they do not trust each other, part of the reason is that the two societies lack a rich diplomatic history with each other. As we saw in the previous chapter, they rarely dealt with each other from their centres of power, from great imperial capital to great imperial capital. Rather, contact was largely through monks, pilgrims, traders, borderland populations, and, for a time, between China's imperial court and regional kingdoms in southern and eastern India. In more modern times, as we will see in the next chapter, they have never been strategic allies except briefly against imperial Japan during the Second World War. As a result, they do not have a long diplomatic past on which to draw to reassure themselves about the motives and behaviours of the other. They cannot turn to a series of positive mutual interactions to illustrate the possibilities of trust building and cooperation.

Over the past two decades, their top leaderships have met regularly, to overcome the legacy of history. At the level of heads of government – prime minister of India and president of China – they have visited each other's country fourteen times in the period 2000 to 2019, sometimes on a state visit and sometimes for multilateral meetings. In addition, they have met at the BRICS summits, the Russia–India–China summits, the G-20 summits, and the East Asia summits, among others. Their foreign ministers, too, have met regularly, and now and then the Indian president goes to China and the Chinese prime minister comes to India. Yet despite scores of meetings intended to build communication and trust, the rising arc of tensions in the past two decades suggests that the levels of miscommunication and mistrust have risen not fallen with the increase in high-level meetings.

A second answer to their continuing disagreements is that India and China have a zero-sum view of security. Neither country seems to be able to accept that a compromise or concession could make both parties more secure. Any ceding of ground in a negotiation is resisted because it implies a loss of security to one side and a corresponding gain to the other side. To be fair, both leaderships did at times countenance what they considered a